

Assignment 3: Case Study

Reflection on Case Study 1: The Journalist and The Public Employee

This case presents a profound ethical dilemma between the utilitarian good of exposing corruption and the deontological duty of honesty in interpersonal relationships. From one perspective, the journalist fulfilled their professional duty. By exposing a scandal that diverted “badly needed public funds,” they served the greater good and upheld the value of justice. The corruption harmed the public, and stopping it arguably outweighs the harm done to one individual employee.

However, my reflection leans heavily on the ethical failure of the journalist’s methods. While the outcome was just, the means were manipulative. The journalist exploited the employee’s loneliness and trust, encouraging a friendship solely to extract information. This violates the Kantian principle that people should never be used merely as a means to an end. The journalist failed in empathy; they prioritized the story over the human being who provided it.

In my opinion, the journalist’s actions were unethical despite the positive public outcome. Professional integrity should not require personal deceit. The journalist could have maintained a professional distance or sought the information through formal investigative channels (like FOI requests or whistleblowing protocols) rather than emotional manipulation. By blurring the lines between “friend” and “source”, the journalist destroyed the employee’s life not just legally, but socially and emotionally. True justice shouldn’t require such a deep personal betrayal.

Reflection on Case Study 2: Social Media Etiquette and Leadership

This case highlights a dual failure of responsibility; the trainee failed to uphold professional standards, but the manager failed to exercise emotional intelligence and leadership. The trainee's behaviour was undoubtedly wrong. Tweeting foul language about a superior is a breach of professional ethics and respect. In the digital age, we must understand that online actions have real-world consequences; "venting" on social media is public defamation, not private frustration.

However, the manager's reaction concerns me more. His goal seemed to be retribution and public shaming rather than correction. By demanding a public apology during a group meeting, he engaged in a power play that likely humiliated the trainee rather than teaching her. This approach lacks resilience; a leader should be secure enough to handle criticism without resorting to "an eye for an eye" tactics.

The manager should not have excused the action, but the approach was wrong. Cyberbullying is distinct from face-to-face conflict because it leaves a permanent digital footprint and often encourages "pile-ons" but the manager's response essentially bullied the trainee back in a physical setting. A better approach would have been a private meeting to discuss the grievance and a formal warning. Leaders should follow a standard of "correct in private, praise in public". By making it a public spectacle, the manager damaged trust within the entire team, ruling through fear rather than respect.